UNDERWATER (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Swimming and exploring underwater changes **movement**, **sight**, **combat**, and **breathing**. This sheet gathers the rules you need at the table.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **Swimming**: each foot moved costs 1 extra foot, unless you have a Swim Speed.
2. **Breath**: 1 + Constitution modifier minutes (30 seconds minimum), then suffocation.
3. **Combat**: melee with Disadvantage unless piercing; ranged with Disadvantage.
4. **Fire**: a fully immersed creature has resistance to fire damage.
5. **Sight**: from 10 to 60 ft depending on water and light. Table rule

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⚠ Underwater visibility: Table rule

- Clear water, bright light: 60 ft.
- Clear water, dim light: 30 ft.
- Murky water or no light: 10 ft.

⚠ Change from 2014

In melee, any **piercing** weapon avoids Disadvantage (no longer a list of 5 weapons). At range, all weapons have Disadvantage (no more exception for the crossbow or thrown weapons). Suffocation gives **Exhaustion** instead of death within a few rounds.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

Extended swimming and deep-water diving are not covered. Fix: the **DM may use the table rule** on the Table Rules page.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the muffled silence, the pressure on the ears, the bubbles, and the light fading as you descend.

Step 1 – Swim:

Without a Swim Speed, each foot moved costs 1 foot of movement **extra**. With a Swim Speed, you use it normally. In rough water, the DM may call for an **Athletics** check (DC set by the DM). Table rule

Example: a character with Speed 30 ft swims 15 ft per turn.

Step 2 – See underwater: Table rule

Sight depends on water and light: 60 ft (clear and bright), 30 ft (clear and dim), 10 ft (murky or no light).

Step 3 – Fight:

- **Melee**: Disadvantage, unless using a piercing weapon or having a Swim Speed.
- **Ranged**: Disadvantage, and the attack automatically misses beyond normal range.
- **Spells**: spell attacks are made without Disadvantage.
- **Fire**: a fully immersed creature has resistance to fire damage.

Step 4 – Hold your breath:

You hold your breath for **1 + Constitution modifier** minutes (30 seconds minimum). Then you suffocate: you gain **1 Exhaustion level per turn**, removed as soon as you breathe again. At level 6, you die.

Example: Con +2, so 3 minutes (30 rounds). On round 31, exhaustion begins.

Step 5 – Fall into water: Table rule

You take falling damage. Table option: a successful DC 15 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check halves it.

Example: a 40-ft fall (4d6): halved if the check succeeds.

Table rules: Table rule

These rules are the author's proposals, absent from the SRD. The DM announces them before the game.

- **Extended swimming**: a Constitution saving throw (DC 10) per hour of swimming. A failure gives 1 level of Exhaustion. With a Swim Speed, no penalty.
- **Deep water**: the DM may count Exhaustion from failures double below 100 ft deep.

Questions:

Can I cast spells underwater?

Yes, with no Disadvantage on spell attacks. A spell with a Verbal component may make you stop holding your breath: the DM decides. The **Water Breathing** spell solves the problem. Table rule

Does a swimming mount cancel Disadvantage?

Our reading: only the attacker's own Swim Speed cancels it, not the mount's. The DM decides. Table rule

How long can I hold my breath in combat?

As long as outside combat: 10 rounds make 1 minute. With Con +3, that is 4 minutes, so you last 40 rounds.

Does fire work underwater?

Fire spells are cast normally, but a fully immersed creature has resistance to fire damage.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

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